



Amrit with his father Narayan Das, wife Varsha, and first born son Akshay

ness. He joined GE in the company's international marketing programme and also stayed in the USA for a while. He rose through the ranks in GE rapidly and went on to become vice president of such a big company at the age of 35. He was trained in advanced modern marketing at the Crotonville facility of GE.

"GE gave a wonderful engineering, market, and international exposure. I was fortunate to meet Jack Welch, the CEO of GE. It was him, after my father, who ignited the fire of being an entrepreneur in me. He told all of us to be the entrepreneurs for the GE units we were heading," he recalls.

Amrit adds, "I owe learning the art of starting a business to L&T. From selling a new product to identifying the need for a new product to everything around a business, it's L&T where I learnt it all."

Both L&T and GE have been clients of the Sahasra Group. GE was one of the first companies that Sahasra had onboarded as clients. Amrit shares that being on the other side with GE was a unique experience as Amrit had already worked with a lot of people from GE, the ones that he was selling solutions to under the Sahasra brand. Amrit recalls how he pitched a solution to one of his previous bosses, who said "Amrit it will be a lot easier for you to sell to us as you know all the processes."

Amrit credits learning to do hard work and perseverance to his father, analytics ability to his math teacher, Mr Sisodiya, and the art of keeping things simple yet effective from GE's former CEO, Jack Welch." Jack used

to stammer, and yet he headed one of the biggest companies on the face of the Earth. The way he simplified things was out of this world. The direction that he gave to GE is still one of the biggest learnings of my life," he says.

Bungalow to flat

It was in 1990 that Amrit submitted his papers and told his family, friends, and colleagues about the entrepreneurial journey he was heading towards. The first hint that made Amrit look in the direction of entrepreneurship included GE's joint venture with Fanuk of Japan. He is still of the view that the person heading him during this venture was below par. Your expectations are always on the higher side when you have worked with the likes of legendary Jack Welch.

"I thought I was working with somebody who had no vision. It's always good to take directions even as president of a company, but this individual was not somebody I wanted to work with or for. Moreover, I knew that I would not be given a free hand as there will be people from GE and Fanuk trying to control and influence my decisions. I was not really willing to do that," he shares.

"Second, I was no longer able to picture myself working for any other company for the next 24 years. I was 36, with at least 24 more years left in me. Third, we wanted to source PCBs from within India for a GE project, and we could find none! We reached out to a couple of companies and requested them to quote prices for PCBs. The lead time these companies were saying was six months. The same PCBs were available from the United States within two to three weeks," recalls Amrit.

This was the moment when Amrit realised there was a big challenge

available to be solved in the market, a challenge that was worth the opportunity of building something of his own in India. "Why don't we set up a PCB plant was a question I asked myself. There is a market, the prices look good. I said all the right ingredients are there. I have identified the business potential," explains Amrit.

Amrit explains all the research and groundwork was done unconsciously while he was working on projects for other companies. Amrit and his partners were able to raise money from a bank consortium. Amrit explains that financial engineering is the first thing that you learn when you start pursuing an entrepreneurial life.

"The office that I started on my own, which employed around eight people, was smaller than my GE cabin. We didn't even have chairs for the vendors who came to visit us the first time. You realise cutting corners is a must when you are an entrepreneur. Sometimes you will have to be the peon and close the office doors at the end of the day. Then there is dealing with the government. How you navigate through tough waters does not come as a part of any research, it starts setting up in your mind unconsciously the day you start working," he explains.

But how does it feel leaving behind a secure job to start something of your own?

"I was not afraid but there were other things that we, as a family, had to compromise upon. For example, I was living in a posh house in Nehru Enclave when working for GE. But as soon as I started my venture my whole family had to shift to a rented small two-bedroom house in Greater Kailash. The first three years of our venture were very good. We were able to capture a good amount of market share. The business was booming," he explains.

What's a business journey with all the ups in it? The government of India opened up the country's doors to imports and the prices of PCBs